

Women and ladies

Just as the Samurai obeyed his lord, the women of his own family had to obey him. Graceful, musical, and artistic, these Samurai ladies were expected to make homes for their lords and masters. By contrast, the peasant women

who labored in the fields had to work as hard as beasts of burden.



A Samurai's most important weapons were his two razor-sharp swords, a long one, called a katana, and a short one called a wakizashi.

A Samurai's armor consisted of six main pieces: the helmet, the face mask, the breast-plate, the sleeves, the shin guards, and the loin guard.



Knowing their place

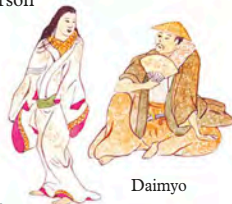
Life in Samurai Japan was strictly organized. From birth, everybody had a fixed place in society. Samurai families belonged to the upper classes.



The godlike Emperor was the official ruler, but the Shogun, his chief general, was really the most powerful person in Japan.



Shogun



Daimyo

The Daimyo were the nobles of Japan, and they were supported by Samurai warriors. They preferred to have nothing to do with money or the buying and selling of goods.



Samurai

Merchants and traders were not given much respect, in spite of their wealth.



Merchants



Lowest of the low were the peasants. They worked on the farms of the Daimyo and were treated like slaves.



Peasant

